

KF 39 Expanded Version of Teachings

Karis is an invitation to a relationship based on mutual generosity.

“Search me, O God, and know my heart. Examine me and know my thoughts. See if there is any way in me that causes pain, and lead me in the ways of eternity.” (Psalm 139:23-24)

0:01 OPENING

0:02 PRESENTING

0:06 KARIS CIRCULATION

0:07 GUIDELINES & LIMITATIONS

0:08 MINDFULNESS & MEDITATION TRAINING

In this lesson we will practice pacing the **Three-Part Breath** while relaxing the perineum and the face muscles. This technique strengthens our ability to focus our minds and manage our bodies. It may also generate a little stress, which gives us the opportunity to exercise courage and endurance. Spend a few minutes practicing this breathing method at the start of your own meditation time. Your goal is to maintain a connection between your mind and body while disconnecting from your stories and distractions. When you find your mind wandering, kindly say to yourself, “Release thoughts,” and then gently reconnect to your breath. Let’s start with relaxed, natural breathing. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

The upright meditation posture gives your body more room to expand. Sit up straight with the crown of your head reaching toward the heavens and your tailbone reaching toward the earth. Lower your chin a little as you lengthen the back of your neck. Breathe naturally while maintaining this posture. *(Pause)* Observe how your body moves and how your back expands as you breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Let’s begin the **Three-Part Breath**. You do not need to work hard at this. Try not to create tension in your body by forcing air either in or out. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Relax your throat and face. It might help to maintain a little Mona Lisa smile throughout the entire breath. Open the space between your eyebrows by allowing the muscles on both sides of your face to relax. Release any tension between your eyebrows and in your jaw. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

When exhaling, focus on the expanded lower ribs and abdomen while the upper chest relaxes. Then allow the lower ribs to deflate just before the abdomen begins collapsing. As you gently pull your abdomen toward your spine on the exhale, keep your perineum and pelvic area relaxed. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Now we will try pacing the breath. During the inhale, I will count out six seconds to give you an approximate idea of the pace. At the top of the inhale, I will count to three while you pause or cease breathing. We will then exhale for a count of six, and at the bottom we will pause for a count of three before beginning the next inhale. You will want to stop exhaling before you run out of air so that you are not gasping for breath when you begin the inhale. If you find that you cannot follow the count, go ahead

and grab a little air here and there. Are you ready? Let's practice. *Inhale 2-3-4-5-6, pause 2-3, exhale 2-3-4-5-6, pause 2-3. (Repeat two more times and use a timer or clock to count each second)*

Now return to relaxed, quiet breathing as you observe what is going on inside your skin. *(Pause 30 seconds)* How did you feel when you paused at the end of the breath? *(Pause)* Did you feel any anxiety? Was there an unwillingness to endure? *(Pause)* With practice, you might begin to enjoy the pause between breaths as a cessation from all effort and a chance to dwell in the stillness of just being. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Pause. Open your eyes and re-engage with your environment. Notice how breathing in this way massages your internal organs, flexes your thoracic structure, and cleanses your mind. The **Three-Part Breath** oxygenates your body and trains you to confidently direct your body, even when it is reacting to stress.

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about this training?")

0:20 KARIS CONFESSION

0:21 TOOLBOX

We are exploring KF Confession 9:

We learn to withdraw from the Idol Self and begin investing in our True Self.

Last week we talked about using **Flow Pages** to ask God. It's so important to ask God about everything. *In the past you have practiced the mindless habit of asking your Idol Self about everything. (Repeat)* Just as a soldier's training develops the ability to react automatically in surprising situations, your KF training develops your ability to automatically ask God. Asking God instantly takes your mind away from judgment and virtue stories and helps prevent choices based on compelling needs. Rather than habitually or compulsively reacting out of fear, self-hate, and pride, you can stop and ask God. Once you have built the neuropaths that automatically ask God in all situations, you are sensitive to the healthy flow of your life; and when you have learned to ask God first, you are on your way to becoming His trustworthy friend. By asking Him, you partner with the Spirit and the Creation to find creative solutions. Without strain, you can respond to life with orientation.

You have been training hard, learning to automatically react in an oriented way to surprising situations, and you may have had some success in resisting the Idol's attempts to hijack your life. You might be experiencing a newfound sense of freedom and power. This can feel euphoric, but it's important to remember this: if the Idol cannot directly derail you, it will find subtle ways to distract you by creating the illusion that you can do more, get away with more, and, perhaps, even fulfill that illusive, idealized glory. When you are running strong, keep in mind that you are still a creature—a very powerful creature, but a creature all the same—living within a certain set of limitations. All human beings have natural limitations of personality, natural cycles, history, and abilities. We are also subject to the limitations of time and resources, of social interaction, and of civil government. We have to consider our limitations, always.

While we are asking God to teach us about our real, unavoidable limitations, we can also productively choose limitations by simplifying our lives. At first, streamlining our lives within those limitations can

require a lot of effort. That extra work often discourages us, so we continue to dissipate our resources in cluttered living. Interior designers understand that simplicity is one of the keys to creating a beautiful space. This kind of simple beauty is harmonious and balanced. Like these interior designers, we can build harmony and balance into our lives by cultivating simplicity. As a result, our lives will be much easier—and more fun. Ask God to show you what is cluttering your life and interfering with the harmony and balance of your True Self. When you get rid of things, activities, and relationships, you create space that draws into your life what is compatible with the person you are becoming. Live in the cycles of life. Trust the process and let the ebb tide go out, taking with it everything that does not complement the new life that is growing within you. Then allow the tide to return, carrying with it gifts from God and from the Creation. Let go of what doesn't work for you anymore. Clear away some possessions and put them in a box. If you don't think about them again, they are not for you. Circulate them. In every activity, ask God and ask yourself, "What is this doing for me?" I hope that you will be honest.

Often, I look back on what seemed at one time to be a tragedy in my life. A tornado blew away our home in Oklahoma and took with it nearly everything I enjoyed and cherished. All the lovely and meaningful things that we had collected while living in other countries and most of the heirlooms that we had inherited were gone. Our lives suddenly became agonizingly simple. I still feel grief over my loss, but I also feel great gratitude. We gained a stable financial base and a more peaceful life that allowed me the freedom to move to a kinder climate and pour my resources into KF.

God is freer to work in you through a simple life. Try withdrawing from an activity or stepping back from relationships that no longer fit your goals. The time, attention, and energy that you give to unnecessary pursuits and unproductive relationships cannot be available for God, His purposes, and for the care of your True Self. There are, of course, some relationships that you can't let go, but you can let go of your old patterns of handling those relationships. Try fasting from an activity for a week or a month, and then assess its value in your life. One KF member fasted from watching the news. He noticed how he was able to keep up with as much news as he needed from his co-workers or through other means. After fasting in this way, he went back to watching the news and instantly noticed how misoriented television news was for him. You might find that fasting from some church activities helps clear the path for the one activity that God needs you to do. You might courageously allow an optional relationship to fade away and then find that the vacancy draws a truly supportive relationship into your life. Whether you are a mother of small children or the leader of an enterprise, you will be more effective if you simplify. Everyone's resources are limited, and the resources you have are there to serve a purpose. You must make choices about which purposes you want them to serve.

Developing a KF routine of self-care requires effort. You have to be intentional about scheduling your training, but don't try to do everything all at once. Just focus on practicing the KF tools that are working for you. You may find it helpful to schedule your KF work around other established routines. For example, you might meditate for five minutes in the parking lot before you go into work.

Your KF training introduces you to a variety of skills that give you the power to deal with your own misorientation, but don't try to master them all at once. Just focus on practicing the KF tools that are working for you today. When you learn to dance or to speak a foreign language, you may have to withdraw from other activities for a week, or even for a year, in order to focus on developing your new skill. It's the same with your KF training. If you want to invest in your True Self, you will have to let go of some pursuits or activities for a time. You are also part of a community. You have to choose how you will support the KF community, just as it supports you. That takes some of your resources, too. Any small effort you make in

your training is an investment, not just for yourself, but for the whole purpose of God. As with any good investment, if you are diligent and committed both to your training and to the KF community, you will eventually accrue great returns. In your **Flow Pages**, explore simplicity. What might a simple life look like for you? What changes might you make? Ask God to teach you to live simply—trimmed for action, ready to respond to His guidance, and able, at a moment's notice, to joyfully step into the flow and let go.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Savior, unload my soul's freight that I might live a simple life for You. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the Toolbox?")

0:30 SHARING

1:00 BIBLE TEACHING

KF Confession 9 reminds us of the two aspects of our effort toward orientation:

We learn to withdraw from the Idol Self and begin investing in our True Self.

Let's turn again to Romans, chapter 6. In our last lesson, I compared our KF training to an immersion course that is teaching us to live in the new country of karis. This country has a new language, a new culture, new rules of engagement, and a new philosophy for living. It is designed and administered by a very different sort of person. That person is God. The Bible teaches that the people who live in this new country are no longer afraid of death because their leader, Jesus, has already conquered death. Those who live in this new country have broken their ties to the old tyranny of the past and have freed themselves to live their lives for God. In this sense, they are beginning life all over again.

In the text for this lesson, Paul tells us that we were designed to serve. We cannot help but serve someone. If we abandon one master, we must find another. In our misorientation, we abandoned God and found another master in our Idol Self. We agreed to serve this Idol's illusions and compulsive needs, and we constructed a way of living that perpetuates the arrogant belief that we can cast off limitations, do exactly what we please, and still be entitled to excellent outcomes. If we observe our behavior, however, we find that no matter how many virtue stories we tell ourselves about our lives, we are not free. We are compelled by unrecognized inner forces that generate a roller-coaster ride of euphoria and self-hate. Paul is encouraging us to choose the slavery that we were designed for. We were designed to serve God, who desires to support our True Self, which seeks true glory in Christ Jesus; we were not designed to serve the Idol, which seeks the *Glory of Me!* While we were wandering around blind and misoriented, Jesus trail-blazed the path back to our original design by becoming what we were created to be. He showed us the truth by being the Truth. He showed us the way by being the Way. He showed us the life by being the Life. He then invited us to join Him on the journey. He became a slave to God, and God glorified Him. That is our path, too.

This is my paraphrase of **Romans 6:12–18**:

¹²Therefore, refuse the rule of misorientation in your body—a rule that tyrannizes you

into heeding the Idol's compulsive need to save its life. Your body, as well as the Idol system, is going to die anyway, so there is no point in losing your true life to save it. ¹³Furthermore, don't allow your physical body to become a weapon in the service of misorientation, assisting the Idol Self to generate more misorientation. Instead use your physical body as a weapon of orientation for God, assisting Him and His purposes as those who have gone beyond death and fear, and are fully alive. ¹⁴In other words, misorientation shall not be your master. Let me explain. You are not living under a legal system, trying to please a misoriented despot. You are living in karis relationship with God and have access to all the privileges of that relationship. ¹⁵So now what? Do we continue to choose misorientation because there is no law or despotic master to punish us? Absolutely not! ¹⁶Perhaps you haven't yet figured out that you will be a slave, whether assisting God or the Idol Self. You are the slave of the one that you listen to and obey. It is your choice either to obey misorientation, which produces death, or to obey God, which orients you and the Creation. ¹⁷But thank God, you who used to be the slaves of misorientation heeded from your hearts the pattern of instruction that was entrusted to you. ¹⁸You were willingly liberated from misorientation and enslaved to orientation.

Take a deep breath.

Paul is letting you know that your slavery is not optional, but your choice of master is. You cannot, however, simply choose a master and immediately comply with his wishes. Successful service requires training. Just as learning to live comfortably in another country requires training, so does learning to serve a new master. Your mission is before you: you are to be weapon of orientation in this world. Paul takes the metaphor further. Under the Idol's tyranny, you had no choice but to serve as secret ninjas defending a fascist society; you have now transferred your allegiance to the freest society in the world. Jesus, your new Captain, will not send you out as a weapon of orientation without first teaching you how to be free from the fascism in your heart. You can only effectively accomplish your mission if you are living as a free citizen, no longer driven by compulsive needs, fear, and pride. As Jesus trains you for that potential, He will regularly invite you to sacrifice your Idol's hope in the *Glory of Me!* When you start to make that sacrifice, you begin to discover the affirming benefits and ever-developing potential of serving Jesus in your True Self. This discovery does not come simply through learning about meditation techniques or reading the **Toolbox** and **Bible Teaching**. You must willingly, humbly, and with effort practice His way of doing things and submit yourself to be trained like a slave.

This is our prayer of commitment:

O Captain, my Captain, make me a weapon of orientation in this world. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the Bible teaching?")

1:10 INTEGRATION

Sip some purified water and you might prepare to take some notes. Assume your meditation posture, and breathe. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Here is our integration focus: *Consider becoming a weapon of orientation in this world. (Repeat) (Pause for 30 seconds)*

The FAITH Process

(Choose from each section a few sentences that are meaningful to you)

Feelings

As you *consider becoming a weapon of orientation in this world*, recognize any reaction you might feel. Welcome whatever is happening inside your skin, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Awareness without judgment

Allow yourself to experience all your thoughts and feelings, without judgment. You might be aware of some resistance or struggle, or you might notice a willingness to explore. *(Pause)* Welcome your experience and the information it brings to you. Breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Inquiry: What is my body saying?

Bring your attention to your body and notice what it is doing as you *consider becoming a weapon of orientation in this world*. What sensations are there? *(Pause)* You might notice what resistance and shutting down or, perhaps, power and trust feel like in your body. *(Pause)* Gently focus your attention on these sensations as you *consider becoming a weapon of orientation in this world*. Breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Talk to Jesus

You might imagine that you are leaning back in the safe and loving arms of Jesus as together you *consider becoming a weapon of orientation*. Are you comfortable with this idea, or are you uncomfortable or shutting down? Just observe. *(Pause)* What do you believe when you consider becoming a weapon of orientation? What story do you want to tell? *(Pause)* Have you ever tried serving God in the past? What happened? *(Pause)* Observe your experience as just information. You might process your experience with a long exhaling breath or the Dragon Breath. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Heal

As you breathe, repeat the word *Welcome*. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

(Pause for 8 seconds or one long breath after each statement)

- Welcome this opportunity to explore a new possibility.
- Welcome the Holy Spirit of truth with an open and inquiring mind.
- Welcome your present reality and the progress you have made.
- Welcome what you are learning about yourself. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Now, as you breathe, you might use the following statements as a confession to the Lord and turn away from the Idol Self. On the exhale, let go.¹

(Pause for 5 seconds after each statement)

- As I become a weapon for God, I let go of being anxious about power and control.
- As I become a weapon for God, I let go of being anxious about esteem and affection.
- As I become a weapon for God, I let go of being anxious about what that might entail.

- As I become a weapon for God, I let go of being anxious about things not going my way. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the integration?")

1:28 ENDING PRAYER

Dear Father and Creator,

Thank You for drawing us together for healing and training. Hold us in the power of this new direction as You continue to guide us to our glory and our mission. Lead us to the next step in our healing this week as we co-labor with You to reorient our lives for a more effective flow and to develop our abilities as weapons of orientation, for the glory and honor of our Lord Jesus. Amen.

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about this meeting?")

1:29 ANNOUNCEMENTS

For the Christmas and New Year holidays, we will consolidate the regular Karis Fellowships meetings into two mega-meetings. Check the website for dates and times. This is a fun and interesting time when all the karis lifeboats link up and we hear voices from other groups. As always, every active KF member is welcome to attend.

*The NHG book study begins soon. Help those you invite with the registration process and consider facilitating one of the sessions as a karis gift.

*(*Except when preparing for the Jubilee Year)*

¹ www.camillecaldwell.com/WelcomePrayer.html. Adapted for Karis Fellowships by Nancy Diven.